KEY POINT We recommend not focusing too much on the contract-like nature of these two artifacts but rather on the mutual discussion of data consumers and producers. In particular, never let the development of a data product be slowed by a not-yet-perfect data contract. It's the discussion that's important, not the final artifact.

Messflix already has an MVP of a self-serve data platform and a few data products, including a basic data catalog. The base work is there, and some data products are as well. So at this point, it's fair to introduce data contracts and sharing agreements in a basic form to make the work of John and his consumers easier. Here are the three main steps:

1. Inspired by the article by Strengholt, the Messflix federated governance body decides to use of a simple web form that can be filled out. This basic data contract is filled out by the data producer of the product. A second web form is used for a joint data-sharing agreement between the producer and consumer. The output of these web forms is stored next to the data catalog. The data catalog contains links to this data contract and agreement.

   The output of step 1 should be that data producers get into the habit of collecting requirements, as discussed at length in this chapter. Data consumers also are getting used to talking to producers. It's about the cultural shift, not about the documents per se.

2. Once your data mesh grows and people get into the habit of communicating, it's time to integrate the data contracts and agreements with all the metadata in your data catalog. Messflix can take this step, after it has a GUI available for data producers and consumers to use. The GUI might be one for data product registration or might be a good data catalog. In any case, after the company has this ready, it integrates the web forms into the GUI and makes sure the agreements and contracts display together with the metadata of the data products.

   The output of step 2 should be an integration of the contracts and agreements into the daily work of every participant.